

Session 26: Repeated Words Between Distant Literary Units

Key Takeaways

- Sometimes the narrative comparison is prompted by an identical repetition in distant narratives. Through the use of key word repetitions, biblical authors lead us to compare and contrast characters in order to advance the narrative argument.
- Biblical authors often compare narratives and create patterns in subtle ways. To find a pattern, watch for embedded key words and images that link stories together, like the repetition of “see and take” in Genesis 3 and Genesis 6.

Narrative Analogy Between Distant Literary Units

Recall the most basic principle of Hebrew poetry: Parallel words and images invite the reader to make comparisons and contrasts, creating deeper insight into both texts. The same principle is at work here.

Genesis 6:1-8 and Genesis 3

Genesis 1:1-2:3

And God saw that it was "good" [7x]

And God blessed them, “Be fruitful and multiply (רבה), fill the land (מלא + ארץ)”

Genesis 3:6

And the woman saw (ראה) that the tree was good (כי טוב) for eating and that it was enticing to the eyes and it was desirable for gaining wisdom

and she took (לקח) its fruit and she ate and she gave to her husband with her and he ate.

Genesis 6:1-2

And it came about when humanity began to multiply (רבה) on the face of the land (ארץ) ...

and the sons of God saw (ויראו) the daughters of humanity (בנות האדם) that they were good

Lead Words and Narrative Analogy Between Distant Literary Units. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

(כי טוב) ,

and they took (לקח) for themselves wives from all which they chose.

Genesis 6:5

And Yahweh saw (וירא) that (כי) multiplied (רבה) was the evil of humanity (רעת האדם) in the land (ארץ).

Genesis 6:11

And the land (ארץ) was ruined before God, and the land was filled (מלא + ארץ) with violence.

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The twin introductions to the flood narrative consist of two literary units, Genesis 6:1-4 and 6:5-8, carefully shaped to coordinate with each other in a narrative analogy.

- Genesis 6:1-4: Humanity's multiplication leads to rebel spiritual beings seeing and taking human women.
- Genesis 6:5-8: Yahweh sees how, as a result of 6:1-4, evil and violence have multiplied in the land.

Both of these analogies are deepened when we recognize their dependence on the narrative analogy in Genesis 1-3.

- The sons of God and daughters of men are compared with Eve and the snake.
- The daughters of men are compared with the tree of knowing good and bad.
- The blessing about the multiplication of humans on the land in Genesis 1 is sadly turned into a multiplication of death in Genesis 6.

Reflection Question

Repeated words can connect sections of text that are both close together and far apart. The question is, how can you know when a repetition is meant to connect different sections or when it is just a coincidence? What are some ideas you have?